

Can a Machine Give a Blessing? AI Calligraphy and the Tết Tradition of Xin Chữ

Background Information

Xin Chữ and the Ông Đồ

In Vietnamese culture, the new year is seen as a fresh start, meaning that starting the Lunar New Year involves specific rituals in order to cultivate luck for the year. Due to this tradition, many people in Vietnam participate in a tradition called "xin chữ," which means asking for calligraphy blessings. Traditionally, xin chữ works by having a person sit down opposite a calligraphy scholar known as an Ông Đồ, and explain their personal goals or family struggles. After this, based on the person's story, the scholar will select a specific character such as "Tâm" for mindfulness or "An" for peace. The words are usually written with a brush using black ink on a red piece of paper, and the paper is then given as a personal blessing for the whole year (Văn Tân).

The Robotic Arm Arrives at Tết

However, with the advancements of AI, many organizations and companies are looking towards introducing industrial robotic arms that are programmed to write calligraphy, under the theme "Tết Công nghệ - Trí tuệ tỏa sáng" ("Hà Nội"). More specifically, these are software models trained on the traditional brushwork of past professional calligraphy scholars to paint custom Vietnamese calligraphy texts. Additionally, with the implementation of AI, a person can now receive their completed texts in a few minutes, a shorter time compared to traditional calligraphy scholars.

Not only are they efficient and quick, but robotic writing arms demonstrated in Hà Nội can also reproduce human writing movements to within 0.02 millimetres of precision ("Cánh tay robot"). However, these AI systems raise a philosophical issue. In particular, when a robotic arm paints a custom calligraphic character on red paper, does the person receive genuine mindfulness, or is it just automated ink on a piece of paper?

Theodor Adorno and the Culture Industry

Tradition Turned into a Product

One compelling argument is rooted in the perspective of Theodor Adorno, a philosopher who wrote about mass production and culture. In the book he co-wrote with Max Horkheimer, *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, written in 1944, Adorno introduced a concept called "Culture Industry". To be precise, Adorno argued that modern industries are turning cultural traditions into mass-produced goods, essentially turning traditions into

something that can be consumed or used quickly (Adorno and Horkheimer). According to Adorno's philosophy, mass production of calligraphy using AI might replace human reflection with standardized products that can be consumed without thinking about it.

Losing the Slow Conversation

When we apply the views of Theodor Adorno to the concept of robotic calligraphy, it shows that an automated system can ruin the values of traditional customs such as calligraphy. To be more specific, when a person visits a calligraphy scholar, it is usually about a slow conversation where that person can reflect on his or her personal choices and discuss how to improve his or her life before receiving a character. On the other hand, when an AI system takes the role of a calligraphy scholar, the field of calligraphy would turn into an extremely rapid custom, where the user does not get the opportunity to discuss with a scholar but rather receives the calligraphy writing instantly. Consequently, Adorno warns us that the value within calligraphy writings is about the deep conversation and reflection with the scholar, so when the calligraphy AI system replaces this, it also removes what makes calligraphy special in the first place (Adorno and Horkheimer).

Walter Benjamin and the Loss of Aura

Aura and Authenticity

Another important idea comes from the work of Walter Benjamin, a German philosopher who examined how technology changes art. In his essay, "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," published in 1935, Benjamin introduced the concept of "Aura". To clarify, aura is defined as the physical presence and human authenticity within a piece of artwork (Benjamin). Once an automated system replicates a calligraphic character, the original aura is lost. Even when a piece of art produced by an AI system appears to be perfectly accurate, the final piece fails to keep the unique essence of the scholar's physical touch (Benjamin).

Where the Blessing Comes From

Under the philosophy of Benjamin, brushstrokes created by an AI calligraphy system do not bring any true spiritual blessing. The main reason for this is that a calligraphy master pours his or her energy and intention into every stroke, and that effort is where the spiritual value of the writing comes from. In contrast, a robotic arm is programmed to follow a predetermined order of strokes. This means that when brushing the strokes to give a person blessings, the AI does not have any moral intent or any emotions towards a piece of calligraphic art work. Overall, according to Benjamin, the blessing stems from the intent and efforts of the calligraphy master when brushing his or her strokes instead of a perfect piece of writing. Therefore, the use of AI in the field of calligraphy will remove the spiritual blessing that it was intended to provide.

Counterpoint: Confucius on Ritual and Sincerity

Li, Xin, and the Inner State

While Benjamin and Adorno highlight the dangers of AI calligraphy systems, the philosophy from Confucius provides us with a different point of view. In classical texts like *The Analects*, Confucius focused on "Li," which means ritual practice, and "Xin," which refers to a moral intent of a person. From this, Confucius argued that ritual forms exist to help an individual participating in the ritual express their inner moral state (Confucius, bk. 3, ch. 3). As a result, according to Confucius, what matters during a ritual is the respect and sincerity within a person's intent rather than the tools used during the ritual (Confucius, bk. 3, ch. 12).

The Robot as a Tool

When looking at the concept of AI calligraphy systems from the lens of Confucius, the spiritual value of an AI calligraphy does not reside inside the brush or AI, but rather in the moral intentions inside a person's own mind when they participate in the tradition. More specifically, even when a person receives an AI written calligraphy, if the person reads the meaning of the characters and makes a genuine commitment for the new year, then the AI calligraphy would have moral purposes. Overall, from the views of Confucius, an AI robot acts as a tool to help a person record their own moral reflection, and as long as a person holds genuine respect in their heart, a tool would not ruin the values that the field of calligraphy generates.

Conclusion

Two Ways of Weighing the Trade

When observing this topic from a wider scope, there is a clear dilemma between preserving artistic traditions or accepting new technological tools. On one hand, philosophers such as Walter Benjamin and Theodor Adorno warn us that implementing technology in traditional calligraphy would strip away the spiritual value of the ritual (Benjamin; Adorno and Horkheimer). Conversely, Confucius contends that spiritual value within calligraphy originates from a person's own intention and sincerity towards the tradition (Confucius, bk. 3, ch. 12).

Ultimately, when a robotic arm paints calligraphic characters, it is dependent on how a person defines spiritual value. To be more specific, if a person interprets spiritual value as something that is generated from the effort and deep conversations with the calligraphy scholar, then incorporating an AI system would be worthless. On the other hand, if a person defines spiritual value as something that could be created through his or her own reverence and moral intentions, then the use of AI calligraphic writing would still have relevance towards helping the receiver generate spiritual values within their mind.

Works Cited

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